

The Fog swirled heavy and metallic through the corridors of the Nostromo wreckage, dense with steam and rot. The UFO sat lodged in the back corner of the trial map like a forgotten corpse, its glass pods dulled with grime and disuse. No one ever used them. No one *should*.

Which is why Gabriel Soma climbed into one.

He moved fast, not panicked, just... calculating. Huntress was close. He could hear her breath between the gaps in her lullaby, short bursts through the mask like she was testing the air for prey. The lockers were an obvious trap. She had been lobbing hatchets all match and was reloading them faster than people could escape the lockers. But the pod? A prop. A useless one. Nobody checked those.

So, he curled himself into the awkward curve of the cradle and let the frosted glass swing shut over him.

The pod door sealed with a hiss and a faint groan of warped hinges grinding closed. Fog clung to the inside of the glass, distorting Gabriel's reflection until it looked like someone else was staring back at him. For a few, trembling breaths it worked. Anna's heavy boots scraped past, the clatter of an axe against a locker door echoing sharp, then silence.

He had made the right call to avoid the locker, he told himself. Nobody successfully hid in lockers with Anna around. Relief cut through him, enough that he let his head fall back against the padded rest. Clever. Clever enough to hide where no one else would think to look. The Entity loved irony, sure, but sometimes improvisation worked. Grinning slightly to himself, he made a mental note to keep an eye out for more little improvised hiding spots like this in the future.

A generator fired in the far distance, reminding him that the trial was still ongoing. Can't stay under frosted glass all day, sadly. Time to go be useful.

He pressed lightly against the glass with the heel of his palm. It gave a little, but no hiss, no release.

Ok, so the door was a little heavier than anticipated. No big. The glass survived what was clearly a devastating wreck, so it was likely a lot sturdier than it looked. Gabriel chuckled nervously and shifted his hands for a better push.

Again. Firmer.

At first it was just stubborn, the pod door creaking but refusing to give. He shifted, shoulder braced awkwardly, shoving harder. No leverage. No angle. He tried again, harder this time. Pounding the glass. Nothing. Then again, with his elbow, feeling the vibration travel back up through his forearm. Still nothing. It wasn't not locked—it was *jammed*. The Entity's fog had corroded the seams so badly it may as well have been welded.

A staleness had crept into the pod, quiet but heavy, like the air was holding its breath. Gabriel rotated as best he could in the tight space, tried to brace a foot against the interior wall. The pod was slick. Narrow. No leverage.

For a moment, he considered yelling for one of the others, but the domain was a decent size. There was no guarantee that they would hear him before Anna did, and this was NOT an ideal position to avoid her in.

His breath came faster than he wanted. The pod's walls sucked it up, recycling his panting back at him, hot and wet. He shoved again, then again, heels drumming against the shallow floor, every thud eating more of the air. A faint rattle started in his chest, and he took a moment to force himself to calm, only managing a few deep breaths before reflexively shoving at the glass again.

"C'mon, c'mon—" His voice fogged the glass. His handprint smeared across it, half-visible from outside.

Time slipped strange in the Fog, but in here it was worse. Minutes stretched thin and brittle. The pod grew tighter, hotter, air thinning until every inhale rasped. He could see his own pulse flutter in his throat in the warped reflection. His arms trembled when he pushed now, coordination leaking away with oxygen, fingertips tingling and clumsy. He shifted again, desperate now for air that tastes like *outside*. The stale rot and chemical stench inside the pod had thickened, pressing at his sinuses like mold.

When he tried to shift yet again, his coordination fumbled. His shoulder hit the curved wall too hard. The thud didn't echo so much as it was swallowed.

The panic didn't come all at once — it *built*, slow and crawling. His breath turned shallow. His limbs started to lock. One hand curled into a tight fist, the other scraped uselessly at the seam of the door until his nail beds burned and his wrist cramped.

Instinct eventually overwrote his coordinated efforts, reducing the even shoving to a desperate beating against the door. His hands were red, one knuckle split from a hit at a bad angle. The pain was muted under the static roar growing in his ears.

He kicked at the inside of the pod, once, twice — there was no angle for force, his kicks mostly siding off the curved surface as he started to shiver.

Somewhere over the scream in his mind, he barely made out Jake's voice, low and cautious somewhere just outside the wreckage.

"Gabriel? You still here? I think she knows we are trying to find that keycard. She's been back and forth like 4 times now for no reason. Where did you get off to?"

He managed a weak *thunk*. Not a punch this time, just a plea.

Jake rounds the corner, eyebrows lifting, eyes going wide. "Oh shit. Are you — seriously? That's where you hid?"

Gabriel didn't answer, much too far into it now. The pod door rattled weakly under his hand, smears of foggy breath painting the inside of the pod with each shallow gasp and the faint thud-thud-thud of shoes kicking at the inside. His eyes were wide, glassy, trying to focus but not finding purchase, chest heaving.

As tempting as it was to tease him over his insanely stupid hiding spot, Jake held it back. Now was *not* the time. Not when Gabriel wouldn't make eye contact. Not when he saw the dried blood along his knuckles or the way his hands wouldn't uncurl.

"Shit. Shitshitshit — hang on, man."

Jake moved fast, on his knees beside the pod in seconds, hands working at the seam. "Okay — okay, it's stuck. Hang on. I've got you."

His callused hands ripped at the seams, searching for a latch, anything. There was nothing but warped metal and rusted lock housings, sealed like a coffin. Gabriel's fingers dragged against the glass again, slower this time.

Jake's pulse spiked. "Not on my watch."

He sprinted to a collapsed wall of the ship, pulling a scrap of bent piping free from the wreckage, jamming it into the seam and wrenching hard. It took him two tries to wedge it in properly, another four to torque the metal enough to *squeal*. The rust shrieked. The whole pod shuddered. Inside, Gabriel's breath hitched, his head knocking faintly against the padding as he tried to stay conscious.

"Stay with me, Gabs. Keep breathing. I've got you."

One more wrench and the seam tore, glass spider-webbing with a crack that roared too loud in the empty wreckage. Jake shoved until the lock gave way, the door slamming open with a gust of stale, burning air.

Jake hauled Gabriel up and over the edge of the pod by the front of his shirt. He poured out, boneless against Jake as he was pulled clear; coughs tearing up through starved lungs, fingers clawing instinctively at Jake's shirt as if still trying to climb away from the pod.

"Easy, easy. You're out." Jake pressed a hand to the back of Gabriel's neck, grounding him, steadying the tremble in his limbs. "She ain't got you. You're okay."

They stayed like that for a while, hunched beside the cracked pod while the Fog curled low and heavy around them. Jake ran slow circles across Gabriel's back, waiting as the adrenaline bled out of starved muscles. Gabriel's shoulders shook — not from panic anymore, but the ghost of it, nerves burning off in a soft, rattled laugh.

"Holy shit...That was — way too close."

Jake let out a breath he hadn't realized he'd been holding. "No kidding. This — this is exactly why we don't improvise, you *absolute dumbass*."

Gabriel stirred, one arm twitching upward, fingers fumbling through his jacket pocket. He pulled out a worn keycard and held it up with the slow, lazy pride of a man who *just barely* won a bet with death.

"Thought you might like a new toolkit," he croaked.

Jake stared at the card, then back at him. At the bruised knuckles, the glassy eyes, the total *lack* of sense that somehow still walked around in a human body.

“You’re a fucking idiot,” he muttered, but took the card anyway.

Gabriel laughed — wheezy, spent, but defiant. Jake huffed out a reluctant chuckle of his own, scrubbing a hand down his face.

“Don’t ever scare me like that again.”

“No promises.”

Behind them, the pod door hung open like a wound, fog curling out from its seams like smoke from a grave. Somewhere distant, the Huntress’s lullaby drifted through the wreckage — soft, echoing, and much too close.

